The Fortunate

by Alexandra Rojhan



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ISBN: 978-1-61387-301-4

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LEO. You looking for the office? It's that way. They told me all the press have to go to the office. This is the gym. No office here. Except coach's, and it's eleven thirty so he's at lunch. I'm not supposed to talk to the press. Except to tell them where the office is.

It's that way.

My name? Leo. Like the lion in the sky. I didn't know about the lion in the sky until Arlan told me about it. I maybe knew about it before, but I didn't remember. But now I got this book, see? It tells me my fortune for the day cuz I'm a Leo. When is your birthday? Okay, let me see.

I haven't been too good at remembering since my accident. That's what I'm supposed to call it. Sounds better than I crashed a car and my brain got hurt.

When is your birthday? Ok, let me look. See I got this book that tells you your fortune for the day. And every day Arlan would stop by my office and say, "What's our day look like?"

Yeah, I knew him. And I was here for the, what did you call it? The tragedy. I don't like it when people use words that mean other words. It's confusing. Cuz maybe the tragedy you mean isn't the tragedy I mean, you know? Like what if you think the part that's sad is the end of the story and I think the sad part is the beginning? That's…confusing.

But I'm not supposed to talk about that. But I could tell you about Arlan, if you want.

Often times, in the wake of tragedy, our cultural focus centers on identifying who is the victim and who is the villain. However, for Leo, a janitor with special needs, the labels of victim and villain often blur together as he copes with a recent tragedy. As a result, he forces us to reconsider who we call a victim and what we learn from villains. The Fortunate *by Alexandra Rojhan.*

LEO. Met him in a dumpster. I'm telling the truth, I swear. I take the trash from the admin out at 12:30 and the trash from the classrooms out at 4. And one day, at 12:30 I open the dumpster and almost threw a bag of old coffee filters on his head.

I said, "Student's not supposed to be in the dumpsters."

He said he, uh, fell in looking at something. So I started looking too. And he said he was joking, so I said, "HA!"

I'm not very good at jokes.

His name was Arlan. After a dead grandpa. I told him my name was Leo, and he said like the lion. I didn't understand, so he told me that Leo was a lion in the sky. See, he was so strong that warriors' clubs, swords, and spears couldn't hurt him. It took a god called Hercules to kill him. And I asked why he killed him, and he said back then lions didn't mean as much as gods. But now, people all over the world look up to that lion every night. So he got his respect after all. I didn't know stars could tell stories like that, but he said that's their whole job.

Then the next day he gave me a book from the stars. It's called a daily horoscope. He wrote me a note, see? It says, "Thanks for helping me." And this book is real convenient for me, cuz it works, too. See I met him on April 4th, and it said "Today a very special friendship will surprise you," and I think nothing's more surprising than a friend who fell in a dumpster.

Except, he told me he didn't fall in. The other boys, the big ones in the football t-shirts put him in there. He said they did that stuff a lot. And so I said you should stay away from them. He could come have lunch with me.

See, back behind the bleachers, there's a ladder that goes all the way up to the roof of the gym. I got a couple folding chairs up there and it's the best view cuz you can see the courtyard and the football fields and the parking lot.

After that, he'd come up and we'd have lunch. It was nice for both of us; having a place to go to. I even gave him a sticker I found at the grocery store of a lion. I gave it to him and said it was a good luck sticker and it'd make things better. But, you know, good luck can't make everything better.

Arlan would come see me sometimes with broken glasses or a cut lip—he didn't lie to me about it. He knew that wasn't nice to do to me because I get confused real easy, so he told me that them boys kept on him. So I went to my principal and I said that those boys were being cruel, and he said that he would handle it and I thought he would. But then…

Last week, I got a call on my walkie talkie, said there was vandalism on the third floor. The word "Faggot" in bright ugly spray paint…right over the top of a sticker of a lion.

I tried. I tried so hard to get that paint cleaned off as fast as I could, but the bell sounded and the hallway filled up and I looked up and saw him. I wanted to tell him that it would be okay,

that he gets a new fortune tomorrow, you know. But he ran away so fast.

The next day, he surprised me in the morning with a visit and I didn't even wait for him to ask. I had my book out and I said, "Today your decisions will change the rest of your life."

I thought that sounded good, but he was real quiet about that. He said something then…but I don't remember what it was. And then he left for class and I went back to work.

It was 12:30. I take the trash from the admin out at 12:30 and the trash from the classrooms out at 4. I thought the seniors were doing firecrackers again in the parking lot because sometimes they like to do that. But then I heard screaming, and I knew something was wrong. All I could think was that Arlan might be in trouble so I ran to the third floor…to his locker…he wasn't there just the rest of that paint and a lot of screaming kids and one girl said, "The gym. He's on the roof of the gym."

I don't remember what I thought. I don't know if I knew it was Arlan then, or if it was before then. But I just remember I had to get to the roof.

He stopped shooting when he saw me. He had a handgun like in the movies. And I thought maybe it was a movie. Maybe my brain got hurt again because Arlan wouldn't be holding a gun and shooting off the roof at people. I was trying to decide if this was a joke or a movie or something and then Arlan said, "Today your decisions will change the rest of your life. I'm so sorry."

I wanted to tell him that I wasn't mad at him. I wanted to tell him that he's gonna be okay and that we get a whole new fortune tomorrow. But then he took that handgun and put it in his mouth and… no, no, NO!

Arlan. He was my friend.

And now I hear what you say about him on TV. He wasn't no monster. They were. The ones who hurt him. I'm sorry those kids got hurt and I'm sorry that they didn't like Arlan, but if you want to know what happened…if you want to know what I think the tragedy was? They killed him. They killed him first.

So, you should just know that part, too.

Oh, before you go, when is your birthday? Oh. You're a too? Well, for us it says…"You are damaged and broken and unhinged. But so are shooting stars and comets. You will be

bright even in your imperfection.'' Don't thank me. Thank Arlan.